

The Oval Office: The Most Famous Office In The World [B2]

Qui vengono prese alcune delle decisioni più importanti della politica statunitense e internazionale. Un ufficio pieno di storia e segreti.



We've seen it countless times in films and on television, but how much do we really know about the Oval Office, the US president's official place of work? This elliptical room in the White House has a rich history and [conceals](#) some surprising secrets. Although a US president has resided in the White House since 1800, the Oval Office wasn't part of the building's original design. It was first created more than a century later for President William Howard Taft (1909-1913), who wanted a room [shaped](#) like the presidential [seal](#). This early Oval Office was located at the centre of the south side of the West Wing, which had recently been added to the White House complex. The West Wing itself was commissioned in 1902 by President Theodore Roosevelt (1901-1909) to provide more space for his growing staff and to accommodate his large family (he had six children.) In 1929, a fire damaged the Oval Office. President Herbert Clark Hoover (1929-1933) [oversaw](#) its restoration and took the opportunity to install air-conditioning, a modern [convenience](#) at the time. President Franklin D. Roosevelt (1933-1945) later made significant changes to the West Wing. Unhappy with its size and [layout](#), he relocated the Oval Office to the southeast corner of the wing and added subterranean offices for security and emergency situations. As Roosevelt used a wheelchair (a consequence of childhood polio,) this new [layout](#) made it easier for him to access the room.

THE RESOLUTE DESK

The desk in the Oval Office is known as the Resolute Desk. [Crafted](#) from the [timbers](#) of the British ship [HMS](#) Resolute, it was a gift from Queen Victoria to President Rutherford B. Hayes (1877-1881) in 1880 and has been used by most presidents since, with notable exceptions including Lyndon B. Johnson (1963-1969), Richard Nixon (1969-1974), and Gerald Ford (1977-1981). [Rumour has it](#) that there's a secret passage beneath the desk. The office connects to the rest of the West Wing through four doors, each leading to different areas: the Rose Garden; a private study and dining room; the main corridor; and the president's secretary's office. Beneath the carpet lie sensors that allow Secret Service agents to track the president's movements at all times, ensuring constant security.

PRESIDENTIAL TASTE

Presidents often redecorate the Oval Office to reflect their personal tastes. J. F. Kennedy (1961-1963) favoured naval motifs and [seascape](#) paintings, Bill Clinton (1993-2001) [displayed](#) portraits of Roosevelt and Lincoln, while George W. Bush (2001-2009) chose Texas landscapes. Barack Obama (2009-2017) [blended](#) traditional and modern art. In his first term, Donald Trump (2017-2021) hung a portrait of controversial populist president Andrew Jackson (1829-1837). In his second term (2025 to the present), Trump transformed the Oval Office into a gold-

themed space, adding [gilded](#) Rococo mirrors, golden [cherubs](#) and [gold-plated](#) ornaments, subsequently declaring it “the best Oval Office ever.”

HISTORICAL SYMBOLISM

Oval rooms may seem impractical. However, they were never just aesthetic and have historical symbolism. They were popular in the 18th century during the era of George Washington, the very first US president (1789-1797), as they were believed to facilitate socialising; at formal receptions, guests would [gather](#) in a circle and the president would walk around and [greet](#) each person by name. More than a century later, the Oval Office is a place where the world’s most important decisions are made and history itself keeps coming full circle. If you want to know more about this topic, read the articles [The White House: The Rooms Of Power](#) and [White House Deluxe: Donald Trump Renovations Inc.](#)

Glossary

- **HMS** = nave di Sua Maestà ('Her/His Majesty's Ship')
- **seascape** = paesaggi marini
- **displayed** = esporre
- **gilded** = dorati
- **greet** = salutare
- **shaped** = a forma di
- **seal** = sigillo
- **timbers** = travi di legno
- **blended** = mischiare
- **cherubs** = cherubini
- **gold-plated** = placcati in oro
- **conceals** = nascondere
- **oversaw** = supervisionare
- **Rumour has it** = si dice che
- **convenience** = comodità
- **layout** = disposizione
- **Crafted** = realizzare
- **gather** = riunirsi